



WIDE Collar

Rohit Bal and Varun Bahl (right)
Peter Pan, shawl or high-neck,
collars went super-size



SARI State

Tarun Tahiliani
and Gaurav
Gupta (right)
The one-shoulder sari
drape shone in style

Goth in a line of woollen ensembles which played with bright colours and structured silhouettes. Making her wifw debut, Khanna created a line of evening wear replete with floor-length flourishes, lantern shapes, jump-suits and caped dresses.

And while Prashant Verma's self-indulgence was yet again on show (with his portrait dresses making a re-appearance), there is no denying this talented designer's penchant for drama and spectacle. Giant, an ode to James Dean, saw Verma brilliantly execute the theme with car wreck survivor dresses, bandage draped bustiers and Porsche Spyder wreckage gowns, aptly accessorised with car headlight handbags and crystallised Swarovski elements. And though Verma dazzled with the intricate construction of pieces like the pink bandage bustier and skirt with 'scintillating wounds', what was more appreciable was his fierce belief in his own statement, which also marked the collections of most of the new brazen bandwagon.

While Chauhan's individualistic streak was seen in his colour palettes and patterns, the designer himself was unwilling to compromise on creativity. Finding no takers for his Goth groove in Mumbai, Chauhan hopes to find buyers in Delhi and keep his style intact. "I have a very strong look and line and aim to stay true to my style," he said.

Matching their resolve is their level of finish and finesse, which could easily put some of our velvet-velour veterans to shame. "Creativity is the core, but finish is of utmost importance," testified Amit GT, who had the European and Middle Eastern buyers making a beeline for his stall.

Off the ramp Delhi-based designer Atsu Sekhose also created quite a buzz. While he stressed on the hand-worked intricacy of his evening wear in easy silhouettes, he made no apologies for his distinctly western swing of style with European colour codes. "Though my main focus right now is the domestic market, my sensibilities are very western. Thankfully, the market is opening up to experimentation," said Sekhose. Second-timer Zubair Kirmani also stressed on quality as opposed to quantity. "Detailing in clothes lifts the quality as well as the image of the brand," said Kirmani, who is determined to sell

only to like-minded buyers.

And while the couture capital's old guard was wining and dining their loyal international buyers and Tokyo based Beams' buyer Tomoko Inuzuka flounced around the venue dressed in Manish Arora, these youngsters were busy bagging domestic deals. Having won orders with Hollywood's chic boutique H. Lorenzo, California-based Anastasia and Armand Hadida's L'Eclaireur, Gaurav Gupta also lauded the changing perceptions of local buyers. "Earlier, they wanted to put salwars under my dresses. But now domestic buyers are picking them up as is and markets like Ahmedabad and Chennai are opening up," he said.

Though the big bang was sorely missing and there was no 'eureka' ensemble moment—with the exception of Rohit Bal's sculpturally evocative Ashta Dhatu—fall-winter 2008 marked the move away from ostentation to symmetry, where innovation was seen in structure and sleeves went super-sized and pleats, tucks and ruched ends gave a new twist to luxurious fabrics. Embroidery gave way to metallic sheens and scintillating drapes, with the sari silhouette making a head-turning appearance.

And despite the dreary disappointment of the Ashish Soni-Anamika Khanna pairing for the Wills finale, the promise displayed by fashion forwards such as Namrata Joshipura, Nandita Basu-Abhishek Gupta, Varun Bahl, Gauri and Nainika and Gaurav Gupta will keep fashion watchers fixated till the curtain rises on yet another season of style. Joshipura's tempered palette combined with pop colour bursts displayed a growing confidence, while ballgown babes Gauri and Nainika sent a cleverly contoured line of nifty dresses and gowns, gladdening the heart of our desi red carpet divas. While Fighter-cock unleashed some tongue-in-cheek humour, insisting "The revolution must wear FC" on graphic tees, Bahl marched to the 'drumbeats of the future' and presented a slick architectural line replete with Indian contexts.

Now only if designers would get to the bottom of the malfunction malaise, and invest in some quality footwear and nipple tape. Better to nip controversies in the bud, don't you think? ■